

knowledgeable about these terms so you know exactly what you're paying for, and what plan is best for you and your family!

Internet Options:

- **Dial Up** is typically what we think of when we remember the beginning stages of the internet, since it was the only thing available for a long time. Dial Up still exists, but in our image and video heavy culture, it's not ideal and very, very slow.
- **DSL** also runs through your phone line but is faster than Dial Up. You can still use your landline phone (if you have one) and be on the internet at the same time. Some DSL connections are not good for streaming video so if that is important, you will want to check the bandwidth of your DSL provider and compare it with the required bandwidth of your streaming service.
- **Cable** runs through your cable line and is offered by cable networks like Time Warner, Comcast, and BrightHouse. It isn't available everywhere, but when it is, it's usually much faster and more reliable.
- **Satellite** is provided by companies like DIRECTV and Dish. It usually comes with high-speed internet, but is also strongly affected by the weather. So you can expect your service to be spotty during heavy rains and snowfalls. It also requires a small satellite dish next to or attached to your home.
- **Wireless** does not mean Wi-Fi; instead it refers to systems that run off cell towers and charge by gigabyte (GB). Examples are wireless cards that plug into your computer or little "wireless hotspot" devices that create a mobile connection to the internet wherever you are. These can get expensive if they are your sole internet source, especially if you watch a lot of online videos. But if you just check email or only do an occasional web search, they actually might be cheaper than a DSL, satellite, or cable plan.

Gear You Need: